WoW: Forever Wraps the Biggest Beta in Franchise History

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World of Warcraft: Forever just concluded "the largest **beta** in **franchise** history," according to Microsoft CEO Satya Nadella. That is a notable milestone for the long-running online game.

Blizzard recently bundled **beta** access with both the War Within and Midnight **expansions**, opening it up to players who want to pay for it. Previously, getting in was purely an opt-in-and-hope-Blizzard-picks-you process. Unofficial tool ClassicPlus.io suggests that over one million characters were created during the **beta**.

Developer Josh Greenfield called the turnout "the craziest numbers I've seen in 17 years working at Blizzard and almost 8 years on classic." In a post on September 18, 2026, he wrote: "Man, it was hard to sleep last night, I was so excited. **Beta** has been... crazy... We've got something really special here."

World of Warcraft: Forever was announced at BlizzCon earlier this year after months of rumors, as a sort of "alternate universe" World of Warcraft: set in the world of the original game, but taking different twists and turns with its plot, **mechanics**, and content. The **beta** ran from September 17 through October 23, and the full game launches on November 4, available to anyone with an existing World of Warcraft **subscription**. The release has been highly anticipated, following high praise for the original World of Warcraft Classic launch several years ago and the popular Season of Discovery game mode, which served as a sort of proto-WoW: Forever for a limited time.

Word Treasure

beta -- A beta is a test version of a game that players try before the full game is released.

franchise -- A franchise is a series of related games that share the same world and name.

expansions -- Expansions are large new parts added to a game, with new stories and content to explore.

subscription -- A subscription is a regular payment that lets a player keep playing a game.

mechanics -- Mechanics are the rules and systems that decide how a game is played.

Background you need

World of Warcraft is a long-running online game in which players create characters and explore a shared fantasy world together.

A beta is a test version of a game that players try before the full release, so makers can find problems and learn what players enjoy.

An expansion adds new stories, places and challenges to a game that players already know, and a subscription lets players keep playing for as long as they pay to stay in the game.

Break it down

LEAD: World of Warcraft: Forever concludes the largest beta in franchise history, according to Microsoft CEO Satya Nadella.

KEY EVENT: The beta wraps ahead of the full launch.

+- ACCESS: Blizzard bundled beta access with the War Within and Midnight expansions, after a previous opt-in-and-hope process.

+- SCALE: Unofficial tool ClassicPlus.io suggests over one million characters were created.

+- REACTION: Developer Josh Greenfield called the turnout the craziest numbers he had seen in his years at Blizzard and on classic.

BACKGROUND: What the game is and why its release is anticipated.

+- ANNOUNCEMENT: Announced at BlizzCon earlier this year after months of rumors.

+- CONCEPT: An alternate universe version set in the original world, with different twists in plot, mechanics and content.

+- CONTEXT: Follows praise for the original World of Warcraft Classic launch and the popular Season of Discovery mode.

WHAT NEXT: The full game launches on November 4 for anyone with an existing World of Warcraft subscription.

Why it matters

The huge beta shows how much demand there is for a fresh take on a long-running game, and its success could shape how Blizzard revives older games for loyal players.

Test what you remember

1. Who described World of Warcraft: Forever's beta as the largest beta in franchise history?

- (A) Blizzard
- (B) Josh Greenfield
- (C) Microsoft CEO Satya Nadella
- (D) ClassicPlus.io

2. How did players previously get into the beta?

- (A) Through a purely opt-in-and-hope-Blizzard-picks-you process
- (B) By attending BlizzCon
- (C) By buying an expansion
- (D) Through an existing subscription

3. According to the unofficial tool ClassicPlus.io, how many characters were created during the beta?

- (A) Under one million
- (B) Over ten million
- (C) Over one million
- (D) Exactly one million

4. When did the beta run?

- (A) Earlier this year at BlizzCon
- (B) From September 18 through November 4
- (C) From September 17 through October 23
- (D) From October 23 through November 4

5. When does the full game launch, and who can play it?

- (A) On October 23, for anyone who bought Midnight
- (B) On September 17, for beta testers only
- (C) On November 4, for new players only
- (D) On November 4, for anyone with an existing World of Warcraft subscription

6. How is World of Warcraft: Forever described in the article?

- (A) A limited-time Season of Discovery game mode
- (B) A sequel that replaces World of Warcraft Classic
- (C) A remake of the original game with the same plot
- (D) A sort of alternate universe World of Warcraft, set in the original world but with different twists in plot, mechanics and content

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: A 3: C 4: C 5: D 6: D

Questions to think about

1. **Microsoft CEO Satya Nadella: Described the beta as the largest beta in franchise history.**

2. **Developer Josh Greenfield: Called the turnout the craziest numbers he had seen in his years at Blizzard and on classic, said he was excited, and said the team had something really special.**

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):